pathogen evolves, for example in the oceans, that attacks chloroplasts. It could wipe out all algae and plant life in the oceans, and jump to the land where it wipes out all land plants. So everything becomes a desert. This is possible; I see nothing to prevent it. But it's not very plausible. It is unlikely ever to happen, but it could be a basis for Cooper's world.

These speculations give us a sense of the kinds of nightmare scenarios that could keep a biologist awake at night. In *Interstellar*, the focus is a lethal generalist blight running rampant over the Earth. But Professor Brand has a secondary worry: humankind's running out of oxygen to breathe.